

THE
WORTH
OF THE
SOUL.

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No. 179.

THE WORTH OF THE SOUL.

THE soul of every man is of more worth to him than all the world. What would it profit him, if he were to gain the whole world, were he thereby to lose his own Soul? Such is the uncertainty of life, he might not long enjoy his power, his riches, and his pleasures. If he could possess all these, with health and friends, and live to very old age, an eternity then succeeds, and all that is past is but as a tale that is told, or as a dream of the night. For a small portion of the things of time men are all activity and life. They are ingenious in managing their trades, careful in preserving their health, and watchful in securing their property. But should the care of the Soul be overlooked? Should the health of the Soul be neglected? Should the future happiness of the Soul be disregarded? How many have lost their Souls through *ignorance, impenitence, unbelief, disobedience, fleshly lusts, love of the world, fear of man, love of ease, or some profitable or pleasant sin, or neglect of the great salvation; yet how plain and decided are the oracles of God on all these points.* Observe each in its order. On the subject of *ignorance*, it is said, "My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge; because thou hast rejected knowledge, I will also reject thee." (Hos. iv. 6.) Of *impenitence*, "Except ye repent, ye shall all likewise perish." (Luke xiii. 3.) Of *unbelief*, "He that believeth not the Son, shall not see life, but the wrath of God abideth on him." (John iii. 36.) Of *disobedience*, "To them who are contentious, and do not obey the truth, but obey unrighteousness, he will render indignation and wrath." (Rom. ii. 8.) Of *fleshly lusts*, "They war against the soul." (1 Pet. ii. 11.) Of *the world*, "Love not the world, neither the things that are in the world; if any man love the world, the love of the Father is not in him." (1 John ii. 15.) Of *the fear of man*, "It bringeth a snare." (Prov. xxix. 25.) "The fearful and unbelieving shall have their part in the lake which burneth with fire and brimstone." (Rev. xxi. 8.) Of the *love of ease*, "If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross, and follow me." (Matt. xvi. 24.) Of the *profits or pleasures of*

sin, “If thy hand offend thee, cut it off. If thine eye offend thee pluck it out.” (Mark ix. 43, 47.) Of *neglect of salvation*, “How shall we escape if we neglect so great salvation?” (Heb. ii. 3.) On this point read also Prov. i. 24–33.

How striking are the examples recorded in the same oracles! *Adam* risked his soul, through desire of vain knowledge, (Gen. iii. 6.) *Cain*, through hatred to true religion, (Heb. xi. 4. 1 John iii. 12.) *Achan*, for a wedge of gold, (Josh. vii. 21.) *Esau*, for a mess of pottage, (Heb. xii. 16.) *Balaam*, for a reward, (Jude 11.) *Absalom*, for a kingdom, (2 Sam. xv. 10.) *Ahab*, for a garden of herbs, (1 Kings xxi. 4.) *Judas*, for thirty pieces of silver, (Matt. xxvi. 14, 15.) *Ananias and Sapphira*, through a lie, (Acts v. 4.) *Herod*, for vain glory, (Acts xii. 22, 23.) *Pontius Pilate*, for popularity, (Mark xv. 15.) *The Gentiles* in general, through a dislike to retain God in their knowledge, (Rom. i. 28.) and the *Jews*, through hypocrisy, self-righteousness, and unbelief. (Matt. xvi. 3, Rom. x. 3. xi. 20.)

Various are the baits that are employed by the great enemy of the human race. His designs are, to keep men in sin, or draw them from true religion, or hinder their peace and usefulness in the ways of God. His warlike stratagems and subtle snares are all to catch souls. (Ephes. vi. 11. 1 Pet. v. 8.) Therefore, through the blessing of God, it may serve as a guard against our danger, if we consider the following things:—

I. *The nature of the Soul*. It is spiritual, and is designed for an eternal existence. (Gen. ii. 7.) It is formed to be the residence of truth, holiness, and happiness. It is capable of knowing, loving, and serving God; (Deut. vi. 5.) and nothing can render it truly happy but this knowledge, love, and service. Then how sad the consideration that error, sin, and misery should occupy it! If it lose an eternity of joy, how dreadful the reverse! It cannot cease to exist. It cannot be annihilated. It must endure positive pain. There is a “worm that dieth not, and a fire that is not quenched.” (Mark ix. 44.) With what anguish will a ruined sinner cry, “How have I hated instruction, and my heart despised reproof.” (Prov. v. 12, 13.) I was warned, but I disregarded the warning. I was invited, but I refused the invitation. I was entreated, but I neglected the entreaty. I was threatened, but I disbelieved the threatening. If an occasional thought of eternity obtruded itself, it was an unwelcome guest. I went to my farm, to my merchandise, to my

pleasures, to my sins; but could find no time or inclination to go to my Bible, my Saviour, my God. Evil spirits have been my tempters, they are now my companions and tormenters. I am without hope; darkness and despair have seized my Soul, “the harvest is past, the summer is ended, and I am not saved.” (Jer. viii. 20.) My sins and negligence are set in dread array before me, and this is their desert. I see others entering into the kingdom of heaven, but I am shut out. (Matt. xxv. 10.) The only sound I hear from heaven, is, *Eternity! Eternity! Eternity!* (Rev. xiv. 10, 11.)

Thus, if we consider the capacity of the Soul for happiness or misery, we may learn something of its nature and worth; and surely this ought to serve as a guard against neglect of its welfare. Shall we run into danger, and risk the loss of so invaluable a treasure? Shall we be content that it should remain doubtful whether we shall be saved or lost? Shall we take such a leap in the dark, when, if we be found wrong, there is no remedy? He who once loses his Soul, loses his all. He is like a merchant whose ship sinks with all his property on board. A man may recover many losses on earth, but the loss of the Soul is a loss never to be repaired. *Once lost, lost for ever.*

Still more shall we discover its worth, if we reflect on:—

II. *The price of its redemption.* O! learn the value of your Souls by that astonishing truth, “*God was manifest in the flesh.*” (1 Tim. iii. 16.) “Though he was rich, yet for our sakes he became poor.” (2 Cor. viii. 9.) He became “a man of sorrows, and acquainted with grief.” (Isaiah liii. 3.) He tabernacled thirty-three years in our evil world. He was obedient to the law for man. (Dan. ix. 24.) He was made a sacrifice for sin. (2 Cor. v. 21. Gal. iii. 13.) “He was wounded for our transgressions.” “He was bruised for our iniquities.” “He poured out his soul unto death.” (Isaiah liii. 5. 12.) By all he did and suffered, by the mystery of his holy incarnation, by his holy nativity and circumcision, by his baptism, fasting, and temptation, by his agony and bloody sweat, by his cross and passion, by his precious death and burial, by his glorious resurrection and ascension, and by his second coming to judge the world, an infinite dignity and incalculable value are stamped on the Soul. “Ye were not redeemed with corruptible things, as silver and gold, but with the precious blood of Christ.” (1 Pet. i. 18, 19.) Shall such a price be paid, and will you not regard your Soul? If immortal

Souls were so precious in the sight of God, that he gave his only begotten Son, that through him they might be saved. If they were so valuable in the sight of the divine Saviour, that he did not shrink from laying down his life for their sake, let then your own Soul be precious in your own sight, and seek its present and everlasting salvation through him, for he freely offers you his salvation, yea, beseeches you to accept it at his hands. (2 Cor. v. 20, and vi. 1.)

To this end, let it be your immediate object to consider,

III. *The means appointed for the soul's spiritual welfare. Ministers labour continually.* "They watch for your Souls as they that must give an account." (Heb. xiii. 17.) They are the appointed messengers of God to warn men to flee from the wrath to come, and to invite them to lay hold on eternal life. (Col. i. 28. 1 Tim. vi. 12.) By them the blessing and the curse are continually set before you. (Deut. xxx. 19.) *The Gospel is preached*, that faith may come by hearing. (Rom. x. 17.) And the spirit of God waiteth to apply it, and make it effectual. (Isa. xxx. 18. Rev. iii. 20.) It is brought near, and its blessings freely offered. (Rom. x. 8–13,) and the consequences of neglecting it are fully stated. (Acts iv. 12. 2 Cor. iv. 3, 4.) *The holy scriptures are written* "for doctrine, reproof, correction, and instruction in righteousness." (2 Tim. iii. 15–17.) They are an infallible guide, "a sure word of prophecy," (2 Pet. i. 19,) a light to guide the soul into the way of peace. (Ps. cxix. 105–130.) *Conscience* admonishes and accuses. (Rom. ii. 15.) Oftentimes, with a voice too powerful to be altogether resisted, it whispers, "Take heed to thy soul." (Acts xxiv. 25.) *Providences* are arranged by infinite wisdom in such manner, that they may speak a warning voice. (Luke xiii. 4. Mark xiii. 37.) *Afflictions* are sent to awaken a concern for eternity. (Isaiah xxxviii. 1.) And the *Holy Spirit* strives, yea, condescends to invite to a conference, with the promise of a happy result. (Gen. vi. 3. Isaiah i. 18. Acts iii. 19.) *Destruction has no covering*, that we may not fall into the pit, (Luke xvi. 23,) and *Heaven darts its splendours* from afar to attract the notice of immortal souls. (Ps. xvi. 11. Rev. xxi. 23–27.) Then neglect not to use those means which are placed within your power. *Wait on God* continually. (Isa. xl. 31.) *Remember that thou keep holy the sabbath day.* (Isaiah lviii. 13, 14.) *Search the scriptures* daily. (Acts xvii. 11, 12.) *Be earnest in prayer.* Cry mightily unto God, to enlighten your mind, and renew a right spirit within you. (Luke xi. 9–13.)

Plead the promises of God, and you will find them faithful and true for the welfare of your souls. (Isa. lxxv. 24.)

Upon the whole, therefore, observe.—They who neglect the means of grace deprive their souls of good. (Heb. iv. 1, 2.) They who do not reverence the Son of God and trust in him, lose their Souls for ever. (John viii. 24.) In this there is great folly, as well as guilt. He who is more anxious about time than eternity, and disregards spiritual things, is more foolish and cruel than the man, who, when his house is on fire, looks after trifles, and exposes himself, or leaves his child to perish in the flames.

Will you postpone the consideration of these things? What, and if this night your soul should be required of you? Be ye therefore ready. (Luke xii. 20–40.) “Behold, *now* is the accepted time, *now* is the day of salvation.” (2 Cor. vi. 2.) “Seek ye the Lord *while he may be found*, call ye upon him *while he is near*,” (Isaiah lv. 6.) lest you resemble the *Roman Emperor* who, in his dying moments, said, “My poor vagrant Soul, whither art thou going;” or the *unbelieving Voltaire*, who declared to his physician, he would give half his fortune to have his life lengthened half a-year; or the *Jewish Rabbi*, who said to them that asked him why he wept, “If they were carrying me before a king of flesh and blood, who is here to-day, and to-morrow in the grave; who may bring me into bondage, but cannot keep me there, only for a season; who may destroy my body, but cannot touch my soul, even in these circumstances I should weep. But now I am going before the King of Kings, the only blessed God, who liveth and endureth for ever and ever, who, if I die impenitent, will consign me to the pit whence there is no redemption.”

Instead of being thus left, with Pagans, Infidels, and Jews, to dread uncertainty, on a subject so amazingly important as the future state of the immortal soul, instead of the dreadful risk which all must run who are careless or indifferent on such a matter, you may, by that grace of the Holy Spirit which you are encouraged to seek, by that repentance towards God, and faith towards our Lord Jesus Christ, which you are invited to exercise, and which is the gift of God, be enabled to triumph over *death*, and say, “I know whom I have believed, and am persuaded that he is able to keep that which I have committed unto him.” (2 Tim. i. 12.) “O death, where is thy sting? O grave, where is thy victory? Thanks be to God, which giveth us

the victory, through our Lord Jesus Christ.” (1 Cor. xv. 55.) You may carry your imagination beyond the grave, and say, in the prospect of an appearance at the *judgment* of the great day, “Who is he that condemneth? It is Christ that died.” (Rom. viii. 34.) You may look forward to *eternity*, and say, “I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith; henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness.” (2 Tim. iv. 6, 7.)

That God of his infinite mercy and love may bless you with this grace, and lead you to the exercise of this repentance and faith; or, if you are now penitent believers in the Lord Jesus Christ, that you may be kept “steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord,” is the hearty desire of the friend who thus wishes to draw your attention to the *Worth of your Souls*, by leading you to consider, *their nature, the price of their redemption, and the means of their spiritual welfare.*

What were thy gain, couldst thou survey
The spacious land, and boundless sea,
And view a world at thy controul,
But lose thyself, th’ immortal soul?

Blessings of mind, or better health,
Can well supply the loss of wealth:
A ruin’d soul what can restore?
That loss can be repair’d no more.

Where will the trembling sinner find
A ransom for the guilty mind?
What jewel of uncounted cost
Can purchase back *that jewel* lost?

What madness thus to throw away
A soul for trifles day by day!
For dear-bought joys yourself undo,
And barter bliss for certain woe!

Amazing folly Lord we own
Our guilt, with penitential moan:

While our vain hearts have been engrost,
With meaner cares, our souls were lost.

For what in nature's spacious range
Would happy saints their bliss exchange?
Or what in time can sinners gain
To balance everlasting pain?



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